KenTender Module Guide: Supplier Portal and Bids

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What the supplier portal is for

The supplier portal is where suppliers find open tenders and send their bids. Anyone can read a published tender without an account. To bid, a supplier registers its organisation, starts a bid on the tender, fills it in and has an authorised person sign and submit it. The bid is built from the published tender, so the supplier answers the tender's own questions and never retypes a requirement, a quantity or a price line.

A submitted bid is sealed in an electronic tender box, and the supplier gets a receipt. Until the deadline the supplier can replace or withdraw it. At the deadline the box closes on its own and the sealed bids go to Bid Opening. Before the opening, no one at the procuring entity can read a bid, or even tell whether one exists.

Inside the system this module is called Bid Submission. The first release covers the same purchases as Tenders: off-the-shelf IT equipment, bought by open tender as a single lot, in Kenya Shillings.

Why it matters: suppliers compete on equal terms against exactly what was published. No one at the entity can see or influence a sealed bid, and every submission, replacement and withdrawal is receipted, so a supplier can prove what it sent and when.

Who uses it

Suppliers do almost all the work. Within a supplier, preparing a bid and sending it are separate rights. The procuring entity's staff are deliberately kept away from bids.

Who	What they do
Public visitor	Finds and reads published tenders. No account is needed.
Supplier Representative	Keeps the organisation's details up to date, starts bids, fills them in and uploads evidence. Cannot submit, replace or withdraw a bid.

Who	What they do
Authorised Signatory	Does everything a Representative does, and also signs, submits, replaces and withdraws bids. Their authority is recorded with start and end dates and supporting evidence.
Tender Security Intake Officer	Assigned by the Head of Procurement Function for a single tender, to record that a paper security original or an issuer's confirmation has arrived. Sees nothing about any bid, not even how many there are.
Head of Procurement Function	Assigns and ends the intake duty. Does not see the intake records, the suppliers or the bids.
Auditor	Sees registrations, receipts, signatures and the record of how each bid was held. Sees nothing a bid says before opening, and can change nothing.
System administrators	Keep the service running. Cannot see what a bid says, and cannot sign, submit, withdraw or open one.

What a person can do depends on their recorded role and its dates, not on the title shown. Someone who works for more than one supplier organisation needs a separate assignment for each, chooses which one they are acting for, and cannot reach another organisation's drafts, evidence or receipts.

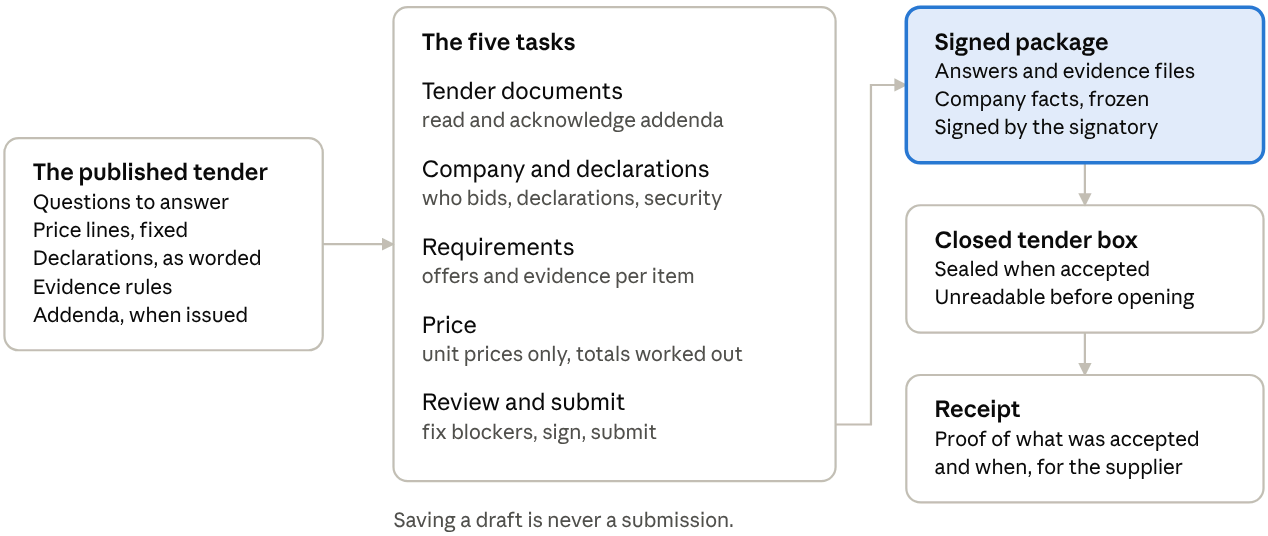
A bid can come from one organisation or, if the tender allows, a joint venture. A joint venture names its lead firm and members and attaches its agreement. Its membership is fixed once the bid is submitted. To change it, the joint venture submits a replacement bid before the deadline.

Registering an account proves only that the organisation controls its email or phone. It says nothing about whether the supplier is qualified, tax compliant or eligible for a reserved tender. Those are judged at evaluation, from the evidence in the bid.

What a bid contains

A bid is not a filled-in PDF. It is a set of answers to the tender's questions, completed in five tasks and then signed and sealed together.

A bid is answered task by task, then signed and sealed as one package



bid contents · five tasks, one signed package, sealed and receipted

Tender documents. The supplier reads the invitation, the tender document, the answers to clarification questions and any addenda. Each addendum must be acknowledged before the bid can be submitted. Until the deadline for questions, the supplier can send a question, which Tenders answers.

Company and declarations. The supplier confirms who is bidding, a contact person for this tender and the email address for formal notices. It accepts the tender's declarations exactly as worded, including the reservation declaration for a reserved tender. The company details are copied from the account when the bid starts. The supplier can refresh them, and they are fixed when the bid is submitted.

This task also covers the tender security. The tender says how security may be provided: the supplier uploads an electronic instrument, the issuer sends it directly, or the supplier uploads a copy and delivers the paper original to the entity. The supplier can see whether its original has been received. An original not yet recorded or an issuer's confirmation not yet received never stops a bid from being submitted. The security is matched to the bid only after opening begins.

Requirements. For each item, the supplier states what it offers against every published requirement and attaches the evidence the tender asks for, such as datasheets or a manufacturer's authorisation. Every file is checked for malware. A file never takes the place of an answer, and a supplier cannot add requirements of its own.

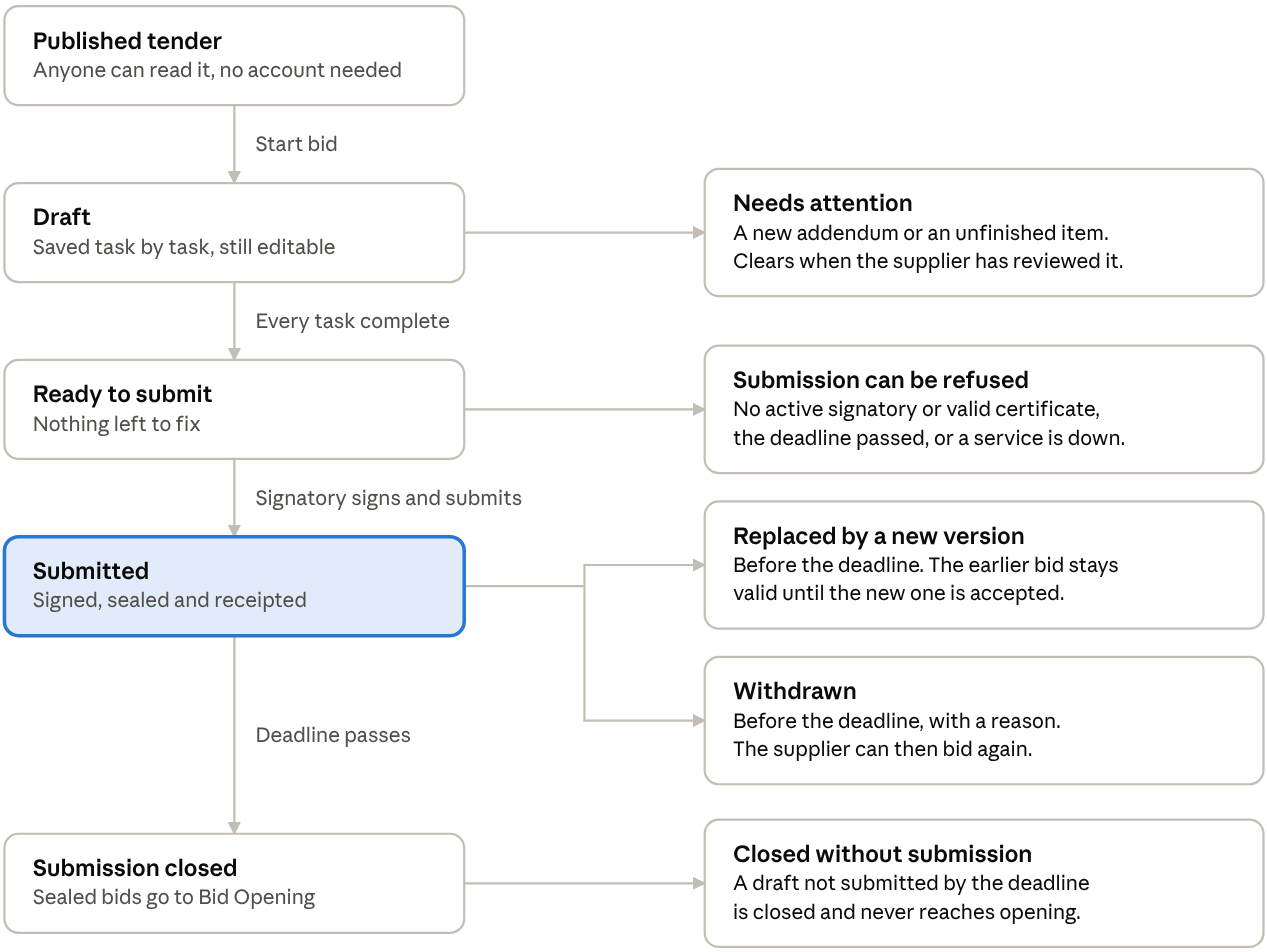
Price. The quantities, units, descriptions, currency and tax treatment are set by the tender. The supplier enters its unit prices, and tax where the tender allows, and the system works out the totals. Discounts, alternative offers, other currencies and uploaded spreadsheets are not accepted.

Review and submit. The supplier sees anything still blocking the bid, with a link to fix it. The authorised signatory then signs and submits.

From started to submitted

A supplier can work on a bid at its own pace, but a bid counts only once the tender box has accepted it and issued a receipt. Until then it is a draft.

A bid becomes real only when it is signed, accepted and receipted



bid lifecycle · five states, five side branches

1. **Register.** Someone from the supplier registers the organisation and verifies its email or phone, which activates the account. A suspended account cannot start or change a bid, though its receipts remain available.
2. **Start a bid.** A Representative or Signatory chooses who is bidding and the address for notices. Starting the bid also registers the supplier on the tender, so it receives notices and can ask questions. There is no separate expression of interest. A supplier can have only one bid on a tender.
3. **Prepare.** The tasks can be done in any order, and the screen always shows what is missing. If an addendum is issued, the bid is marked as needing attention until the supplier acknowledges it and checks the answers it affects. Answers it does not affect are kept. A bid already submitted stays sealed and is not changed; if the addendum calls for different answers, the supplier must submit a replacement before the revised deadline.
4. **Submit.** Only an Authorised Signatory can submit. The system checks everything once more, the signatory signs with a licensed digital signature, and the tender box accepts the bid and issues a receipt. The deadline is judged by the system's own clock, not the supplier's computer. If anything fails along the way, nothing is submitted and the draft is kept.
5. **Replace or withdraw.** Before the deadline, the signatory can submit a replacement. The earlier bid stays valid until the new one is accepted. The signatory can also withdraw the bid, giving a reason, and the supplier may then bid again. Each action gets its own receipt, and nothing is deleted.
6. **Close.** At the deadline the box closes automatically. No one, administrators included, can extend, reopen or backdate it. Drafts that were never submitted are closed and do not go to opening.

Is submission switched on? The portal works end to end on the demonstration site, using test services for signing, the clock and the tender box. Before live use, the owner must approve the real arrangements: whose digital certificates are accepted, who runs the tender box and holds its keys, which clock sets the deadline, and what happens when a result is uncertain. Until then, suppliers are told that electronic submission is not yet available. They can prepare and save drafts but cannot submit them.

In the demonstration data, four supplier organisations have started 22 bids across nine tenders. Eighteen have been submitted, and four are drafts on a tender that is still open for bids.

How a bid is kept safe until opening

Until the opening, no one at the procuring entity, system administrators included, can learn whether bids exist, how many there are, who sent them or what they say.

Sealed on arrival. A submitted bid is encrypted in the tender box. The portal itself cannot read it, and nothing in the system can show, preview or download it before opening. Every screen and report looks the same whether the box is empty or full.

No back door. If a service or a key fails, the bid simply stays sealed. There is no emergency override: the owner has ruled that its absence "does not justify an administrator bypass". A reviewed recovery procedure must be in place before live use.

Receipts. Each submission, replacement and withdrawal gets its own receipt, showing the reference, the tender, the supplier, the version and the times in East Africa Time. A receipt is issued only when the tender box accepts the bid. Sending the same bid twice returns the same receipt.

Tender security, the one exception. The intake officer learns that a supplier presented security for a tender. That hints at interest, though it does not show whether a bid was submitted. For that reason the intake officer cannot sit on that tender's opening or evaluation committee, and no committee member can hold the duty. Neither can the Head of Procurement Function, who is the evaluation secretary by office.

Nothing changed, nothing late. Submitted bids, receipts and signatures are never edited or deleted, and nothing can be submitted, replaced or withdrawn after the deadline.

What the rest of the system takes from bids

The portal passes on only what each stage is entitled to see. It never opens, evaluates or scores a bid.

Module	What it takes
Tenders	The suppliers who have started a bid, with their notice addresses, and the suppliers' questions. Tenders answers the questions and sends the notices.

Module	What it takes
Bid Opening	At the deadline, the sealed bids, each with its history of submissions, replacements and withdrawals and proof that it was held securely. The opening itself belongs to Bid Opening.
Evaluation	After opening, the submitted answers, prices, evidence, signatures and receipts, read directly rather than retyped. If something cannot be read, Evaluation is told so, never that the bid was empty.
Evaluation, for questions to bidders	When evaluators ask a supplier a question after opening, it appears in that supplier's bid and the supplier replies there. A reply never changes the bid.
Award	Nothing directly. It receives what it needs through Evaluation.

The portal relies on Tenders for the published tender, addenda, answers to questions, notices and the deadline; on System setup for support and legal links; and on platform services for digital signatures, the trusted clock, the tender box and malware checks.

Safeguards

- **Only what was published.** Every answer relates to a question in the published tender. Suppliers cannot add requirements, price lines or criteria, and the system cannot demand anything the tender did not ask for.
- **A real signature.** A typed name, an image, a tick-box or a password is not a signature. Only a verified digital signature counts.
- **Registration is not approval.** The portal never describes a supplier as approved, qualified or eligible.
- **No internal figures.** Suppliers never see the entity's estimate, budget or planning figures.
- **No dead ends.** When an action is blocked, the supplier is told why and what to do, and the draft is kept.
- **Full history.** Every registration, saved task, accepted file, signature, submission, replacement and withdrawal is recorded with who did it and when.